

Session 10: Passover Ritual

Key Takeaways

- The instructions for celebrating the Passover ritual initiate the opportunity for later generations to participate in the events of Israel's founding story.
- The Hebrew word *pesach*, often translated "passover," can also be translated as "protect," and this translation seems to fit the [Exodus 12](#) event most accurately.
- Exodus gives us an interpretive lens through which we see God working for the liberation of the oppressed so that the world will know who he is.

The Literary Function of the Passover

Why interrupt an epic narrative with ritual? Performative ritual allows every generation of Israelites to participate in this foundational event and make it part of their own story.

"The historical event is at one and the same time a liturgical event."

Fretheim, Terence E. (2010). [Exodus \(Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching\)](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 136.

Passover

This event initiates a new calendar ([Exod. 12:2](#)). It is a new creation event, fulfilling God's promise to Abraham in [Genesis 15:13-16](#).

Translating Passover

What is the Passover? Has the word "passover" been mistranslated? According to the Dictionary of Classical Hebrew, the verb פסח (*pasach*) can mean:

1. Pass over, spare (?)
2. Limp, leap
3. Protect (?)

The third meaning seems most appropriate in these contexts.

Exodus 12:23 Instructor's Translation

And YHWH will pass through [unrelated word] to strike the Egyptians and will see the blood upon the lintel and the two door posts. And YHWH will פסח **the doorway** and **will not allow the destroyer to enter your**

house to strike you.

Isaiah 31:5 Instructor's Translation

Like swooping birds, thus will YHWH of hosts protect Jerusalem; he will protect and deliver, **פֶּסַח** and rescue.

Who Can Participate in the Passover?

God gives restrictions in [Exodus 12:43-49](#) based on covenant lines, not on ethnicity. Circumcision is the approved sign of covenant membership.

The Firstborn Belong to YHWH

YHWH's claim on the firstborn of Egypt extends to the Israelites as well. Every firstborn belongs to him and must be sacrificed (in the case of animals) or redeemed (in the case of children) for five shekels ([Num. 18:15](#)).

Wilda Gafney argues that this law includes daughters as well as sons. Although Exodus 12 [verses 12](#) and [15](#) specify only male animals are to be sacrificed or redeemed, the language for humans is arguably generic (*bekhor*, 'adam, *beney Israel*). For more information, see Gafney, Wilda C. (2017). [Womanist Midrash: A Reintroduction to the Women of the Torah and the Throne](#). Westminster John Knox Press.

Exodus and Liberation Theology

Exodus has been a major source of inspiration for liberation theologies of Latin America and the American South. When we read the Bible with the oppressed, we notice two things. 1. "Salvation" is not primarily spiritual or other-worldly, but sets the oppressed free from those who abuse earthly power. 2. Humans are invited to participate in the task of liberation here and now.

Here are a few more key things to notice.

- Exodus does not liberate for the sake of freedom but for worship of YHWH.
- The people go from serving Pharaoh to serving YHWH.
- The family of Abraham is the specific target of YHWH's deliverance.
- The liberation of the Hebrews becomes the basis for the call to treat others well in biblical law.

Reflection Question

Did you previously know that the Hebrew word *pesach*, translated as "passover," could also mean "protect"? Does this translation help make sense of the Passover event and God's action on behalf of Israel?